



GAZA AT A CROSSROADS: A STRUGGLE OF WILLS OVER “THE DAY AFTER THE WAR”



THE PATH OF WAR AND OCCUPATION

Prolonging conflict
and occupation



THE PATH OF ELECTIONS AND RENEWING LEGITIMACY

Restoring national unity
through legitimate
representation



THE PATH OF INTERNATIONAL ADMINISTRATION AND TRANSITIONAL ARRANGEMENTS

Managing the transition
and shaping the future



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Position Assessment

Gaza Between Three Tracks:
A Contest of Wills over the "Day After the War"

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An independent, non-profit Palestinian institution, established out of a sense of responsibility toward Palestinian communities, to meet their political, economic, and social needs through the provision of in-depth research services. The Center works to empower Palestinian society at both the individual and collective levels, and to address its various challenges.

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Executive Summary

This paper examines the struggle over the future of the Gaza Strip in the “day after the war” phase, treating it as a contest over reshaping the Strip’s political, security, and administrative reality, rather than merely a set of post-war arrangements. It reviews three main tracks: the Israeli track, which seeks to impose new security and geographic realities through field control and forced displacement; the American track, based on international and administrative arrangements under the banners of reconstruction and investment, operating under the umbrella of the Board of Peace; and the Palestinian track, which proposes reunifying Palestinian political geography through elections and renewing the legitimacy of national institutions.

The paper argues that, at the current stage, the Israeli track holds a field advantage owing to its instruments of power and its capacity to impose facts on the ground, while the American and Palestinian tracks face challenges related to a lack of vision and the capacity for implementation. Nevertheless, the Palestinian track remains the one most closely tied to preserving the unity of the national project, which requires national consensus and the translation of political legitimacy into effective capacity on the ground, in order to prevent Gaza from being reshaped outside its Palestinian national framework.

Abstract

This paper examines the competing visions for Gaza’s future in the “day after” phase, focusing on three tracks: the Israeli effort to reshape the security and territorial reality, the American approach based on international administrative and reconstruction arrangements, and the Palestinian path centered on elections and political renewal.

The paper argues that Israel currently holds a field advantage due to its control and capacity to impose realities, while the other tracks face political and practical challenges. However, the Palestinian track remains the most aligned with preserving national unity, requiring internal consensus and the transformation of political legitimacy into effective capacity on the ground.

Introduction:

The battle over the Gaza Strip is no longer confined to halting the war or reconstruction; it has moved to a more complex and dangerous level, centered on the struggle to shape the “day after the war” and to determine the identity of the authority that will hold the capacity to govern the Strip and impose its political, security, and administrative will over the land and population. Amid the absence of a comprehensive political settlement, the erosion of centralized Palestinian decision-making, and the multiplicity of regional and international parties engaged in shaping Gaza’s future, the Strip has become an open arena for competing projects and strategic visions whose objectives extend well beyond its geographic borders.

In this context, Gaza stands before three tracks that are simultaneously contradictory and intersecting, each seeking to reshape the political, security, and administrative reality according to its own interests and priorities. There is an Israeli project working to re-engineer the security environment and impose new facts on the ground; an international track seeking to build an administrative and security system under an international umbrella, with economic and investment objectives; and a Palestinian track that proposes restoring the unity of the political system and renewing its legitimacy through elections. The conflict over the Strip’s future, and its place within the Palestinian and regional political geography, continues to deepen.

The core problem this paper addresses is that this competition is not taking place among tracks equal in their instruments of power and capacity to act. While certain parties possess the ability to impose facts on the ground and craft new security and administrative arrangements, the Palestinian track — despite the political and national legitimacy it possesses — remains limited in its capacity to translate its vision into an effective presence on the ground. This gives rise to the central question: What is the future of the Gaza Strip amid the multiplicity of conflicting political, security, and administrative tracks? And how will the existing balance of power shape the Strip’s place within the Palestinian national project?

First: The Israeli Track (Security and Administrative Control):

The Israeli track seeks to re-engineer the security, political, and administrative reality in the Gaza Strip. Israel’s vision is not limited to militarily weakening Hamas; it extends to reshaping the Strip’s internal environment by expanding the “yellow line” zone and strengthening the role of militias and local armed groups, thereby creating new security facts on the ground and dismantling the centrality of authority within Gaza.

The Israeli track benefits from the continuation of the status quo and the stalled transition to the second phase of President Trump’s plan, since Hamas’s continued presence and the ongoing dispute over weapons provide justification for sustaining a military presence and imposing new facts on the ground. The paradox is that Israel — despite its declared rejection of Hamas governance — practically benefits from Hamas’s continuity, using it as a pretext to obstruct any political or administrative alternative and to keep Gaza within a cycle of security threat, away from a political-solution track.

The features of this track are evident in the statements of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who tied the reconstruction of the Gaza Strip to the dismantling of its military infrastructure and disarmament, while simultaneously entrenching what he described as a “new Gaza perimeter inside Gaza.” This framing reveals an Israeli orientation toward moving the security belt into the interior of the Strip and reshaping its security geography, while keeping the option of the population’s departure present in political discourse. In this way, reconstruction is transformed from a humanitarian entitlement into a pressure tool conditioned on Israeli security arrangements, entrenching new facts on the ground before any transition to a political settlement.⁽¹⁾

On the ground, Israel is moving to entrench its control over wider areas of the Gaza Strip, tying its field measures to consultation with the Board of Peace and international parties. Netanyahu’s statements regarding the coordination of measures in Gaza with the Board reveal an area of overlap between the Israeli and American tracks: Israel seeks to expand its security and geographic influence, while Washington works to manage these shifts within broader political and security arrangements for the “day after” phase. This raises questions as to whether the Board of Peace constitutes a framework for restraining Israeli expansion, or merely an umbrella for managing the facts Israel imposes on the ground.⁽²⁾

The recent statements of Israeli Defense Minister Israel Katz likewise reveal that the scale of destruction in the Gaza Strip is not viewed within Israeli decision-making circles as an incidental result of military operations, but rather as part of a deliberate policy to reshape the Strip’s geographic and security reality. During a tour of northern Gaza, Katz expressed satisfaction at the scenes of destruction, linking them to a policy that — according to the Israeli narrative — aimed to “remove threats.” Even more indicative was his announcement of plans to establish three military-type strongholds inside the Strip.⁽³⁾

Katz’s statements reflect a shift in Israeli operational doctrine toward Gaza, from a pattern of “raid and withdraw” to a logic of permanence and spatial control, and the re-engineering of the security domain — something he expressed clearly when he noted that the Israeli army had become “present inside,” as opposed to pushing fighters outward and destroying homes. Accordingly, the destruction does not appear separate from a broader political and security vision that seeks to produce a new geography within the Strip, entrench a long-term military presence, and impose field facts that precede any negotiation over “day after” arrangements.⁽⁴⁾

From this perspective, the expansion of the yellow line zone, the support for local armed formations, and the establishment of military-type strongholds inside the Gaza Strip can be viewed as interconnected components of an Israeli approach aimed at reshaping the Strip’s security and geographic environment. These measures are likely to affect the nature of any future arrangements by weakening the capacity of any central Palestinian authority to restore comprehensive control over Gaza, and by complicating the prospects for reintegrating it within a unified Palestinian political framework.

(1) Netanyahu: Disarming Gaza a condition for reconstruction, (14 July 2026), Riyadh, Al Arabiya. [Link](#)

(2) Netanyahu, after speaking of expanding the occupation of Gaza: We will coordinate our steps with the Board of Peace, (3 June 2026), Ankara, Anadolu Agency. [Link](#)

(3) Katz: Destroying Gaza is a deliberate policy and it gives me a good feeling, (14 July 2026), Al Jazeera Net. [Link](#)

(4) Katz: Destroying Gaza is a deliberate policy and it gives me a good feeling, (14 July 2026), Al Jazeera Net. [Link](#)

Second: The American Track (International Trusteeship and the Board of Peace):

The American track consists of the Board of Peace framework, the international force, and the administrative committee, serving as a framework for managing the “day after” phase in the Gaza Strip. Although it is framed around reconstruction, investment, and improving the economic situation, it reflects a broader orientation toward reshaping Gaza’s position within the regional and international equation, and entrenching a direct American presence on the eastern Mediterranean. In this sense, this track does not regard Gaza merely as an internal Palestinian matter, but as a geopolitical space that can be reshaped, in security and economic terms, within a broader American vision for the region.

American objectives in the Gaza Strip revolve around strengthening Washington’s geopolitical influence in the Middle East, protecting Israel’s strategic interests, and countering the growing influence of international and regional rivals. In this context, there are indications of an American repositioning in the region, alongside talk of military and security arrangements near the Gaza Strip, and a stalled transition within President Donald Trump’s plan.

This orientation reflects an American effort to impose new field and political balances, allowing Washington to manage and pace Israeli conduct on the one hand, and to redraw the map of regional influence on the other, amid intensifying competition among major powers. American engagement in Gaza’s “day after,” then, becomes part of a broader geopolitical vision that extends beyond reconstruction and management of the Strip toward entrenching a long-term American strategic presence on the eastern Mediterranean.⁽¹⁾

As part of the transition to the second phase, the American administration drafted a resolution at the UN Security Council permitting the establishment of an International Stabilization Force (ISF) in the Gaza Strip for an initial period of two years, renewable.⁽²⁾

The resolution stipulates that this force will operate in cooperation with a council called the Board of Peace (BoP) — a transitional body that also oversees temporary administration in Gaza and coordinates with Egypt and Israel. This force is to oversee the disarmament of Gaza, and the proposed Israeli security forces will be asked to oversee the disarmament of the Gaza Strip, “including the destruction and prevention of the rebuilding of military, terrorist, and offensive infrastructure, in addition to the permanent disarmament of non-governmental armed groups” — a reference to Hamas and other Palestinian organizations operating in Gaza. The force will also be tasked with protecting civilians in Gaza, supporting humanitarian relief operations, meeting logistical needs, and training Palestinian Authority police officers stationed in Gaza.⁽³⁾

(1) New American positioning on Gaza's borders, and its most prominent goals, (12 November 2025), Sky News Arabia. [Link](#)

(2) Michelle Nichols, (November 5, 2025), US may ask UN to mandate international force in Gaza for two years, Reuters. [Link](#)

(3) U.S. Reportedly Drafts UN Security Council Resolution for Establishment of International Stabilization Force in Gaza, (November 4, 2025), FDD. [Link](#)

UN Security Council Resolution 2803 constituted a pivotal turning point in the Trump administration's efforts to expand its presence in the Gaza file. The resolution granted international legal cover for multifaceted intervention — political, security, and economic — in managing the Strip during the transitional phase. Under this resolution, the formation of an international stabilization force in Gaza was announced, alongside the establishment of a transitional administrative body under direct international supervision, in which the American administration plays the most prominent role in terms of planning and implementation.⁽¹⁾

Resolution 2803 also gave Washington a free hand in shaping the nature of the phase following the ceasefire, through oversight of the deployment of a multinational force whose leadership and operational structure are selected with direct American support and direction. The resolution set out a set of general guidelines regulating the Board's powers and responsibilities during the transitional phase, as follows:⁽²⁾

- **Political and administrative powers:** Establishing the general framework for transitional governance in Gaza, overseeing the Palestinian technocratic committee, representing transitional Gaza in an international legal capacity, and preparing periodic reports to the Security Council (every 6 months).
- **Economic and financial powers:** Coordinating international financing for reconstruction, establishing financial mechanisms and funding pools (in cooperation with the World Bank), and managing funds allocated for reconstruction through donor-governed mechanisms.
- **Humanitarian and service-related powers:** Ensuring the entry of aid, preventing its diversion for military purposes, and overseeing public services, municipalities, health, and education.
- **Shared security powers:** Strategic command of the International Stabilization Force (ISF), setting the stability criteria required for the withdrawal of the Israeli army, and overseeing Palestinian police training programs.
- **Powers relating to movement and crossings:** Regulating the movement of people and goods in line with the comprehensive plan, and coordinating with Egypt and Israel on border crossings.

On Friday, 31 July 2026, the Board of Peace published a “roadmap” for completing the implementation of President Donald Trump's plan to end the war in the Strip. The roadmap sets out the principles and executive mechanisms for the coming phase, including arrangements for halting military operations, transferring administration of the Strip to a Palestinian civilian committee, restructuring the security apparatus, and Israeli withdrawal, alongside reconstruction. The document's publication came after reaching an “agreement on the disposal of weapons and the transition to civilian administration in Gaza,” a step the

(1) Position Assessment, (8 December 2025), The escalating role of the Trump administration in the Gaza Strip: between political mediation and economic ambitions, Ramallah, Palestine, Palestinian Research Center. [Link](#)

(2) Yasser Manna, (20 November 2025), Security Council Resolution 2803: American trusteeship or a political solution? Ramallah, Palestine, Palestinian Center for Israeli Studies – Madar. [Link](#)

Board of Peace's Chief Executive, Nikolaj Mladenov, described as paving the way for the start of the second phase of the peace plan.⁽¹⁾

The Israeli occupation government conveyed to the "Board of Peace" — responsible for implementing the calm agreement in Gaza — its objections to three points in the agreement announced with Hamas on Friday, following the movement's agreement to disarm, according to the Israeli newspaper Haaretz on Sunday, citing two sources familiar with the details. According to one of the sources, the three points Israel does not agree to are: not destroying the weapons to be collected from Hamas, the participation of Qatar and Turkey in the verification process, and the absence of freedom of military action for the Israeli occupation army in the areas that will fall under the responsibility of the International Stabilization Force.⁽²⁾

Although this track is presented as the most likely option for ending the war on the Gaza Strip and resolving the current crisis, it faces a series of structural challenges that weaken its prospects for success. On one hand, the American vision for the Strip's future still lacks clarity, amid the obstacles Israel places in the way of implementing this track, and the decline in international support — European support in particular — as well as the stalled transition to more advanced phases due to the continuing dispute over the weapons issue. Challenges also arise concerning the exorbitant financial cost of managing the coming phase, and the unwillingness of the United States to bear the burdens of administration and financing alone, alongside persistent differences with Israel over the nature and limits of the American role in Gaza. At the same time, this track raises serious questions about the possible reproduction of a new form of international trusteeship, in which reconstruction and investment are used as tools to manage and contain the conflict rather than resolve it politically — which could entrench long-term transitional arrangements and deepen the separation of the Gaza Strip from its Palestinian national framework.

Third: The Palestinian Track (The Ballot Box):

This track consists of the return of the Palestinian Authority to take the initiative in the Gaza Strip, with the aim of restoring the unity of Palestinian political geography and unifying Palestinian institutions through the ballot box. It proceeds from the premise that Gaza's crisis is not separate from the crisis of the Palestinian political system, and that confronting projects to reshape the Strip begins with renewing political legitimacy, rebuilding institutions, and reforming the administrative and security systems — thereby paving the way for reintegrating the West Bank and the Gaza Strip within a unified Palestinian political system, and for restoring the settlement track on the basis of the two-state solution.

This track is reinforced by an international and Arab orientation pushing to bring the Palestinian question back within the framework of a political settlement and the application of the two-state solution — reflected in the UN conference on the peaceful settlement of the Palestinian question, held under French-Saudi sponsorship. This orientation gives the Palestinian track an opportunity to rebuild legitimacy and unify institutions through elections,

(1) In detail: the Board of Peace publishes the terms of the "Gaza roadmap," (31 July 2026), Riyadh, Al Arabiya.

(2) Israel informs the "Board of Peace" of its objection to 3 clauses in the Gaza agreement, (2 August 2026), London, Al-Araby Al-Jadeed. [Link](#)

paving the way for a new political horizon. However, U.S. opposition to this track reveals a clear divergence between a vision seeking to restore the centrality of the political solution and another focused on managing Gaza and “day after” arrangements according to security and geopolitical considerations.⁽¹⁾

This track seeks to reunify Palestinian political geography through the ballot box, viewed as a tool for renewing legitimacy and rebuilding the Palestinian political center. Elections also represent a gateway to restoring trust in institutions and broadening the base of political participation, particularly for women and youth, in light of the electoral amendments that strengthen women’s representation and lower the candidacy age — allowing for wider participation in shaping the future of the Palestinian political system and preparing it for the transformations of the coming phase.

Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas issued a presidential decree setting Saturday, 28 November 2026, as the date for legislative elections — the first of their kind since 2006 — as part of reforms demanded by the international community.⁽²⁾

The 2026 amendment to the General Elections Law reinforced the process of renewing the political system and broadening participation, by increasing the number of Legislative Council members to 200, lowering the candidacy age to 23, and raising women’s representation to around 30%.⁽³⁾

The amendment also lowered the electoral threshold to 1%, expanding the chances of representation for small and independent lists within the Legislative Council and reshaping the map of political representation on a relatively more open basis.⁽⁴⁾

It also tied candidacy to commitment to the Palestine Liberation Organization, its political and national program, and the resolutions of international legitimacy — a step aimed at reorganizing political representation within a unified national frame of reference.

The call for Palestinian elections gained fresh momentum with President Mahmoud Abbas’s announcement that the phase following the Eighth General Conference of Fatah would see progress toward completing democratic entitlements, including preparations for general presidential and legislative elections, alongside drafting the constitution, the parties law, and the general elections law. He also affirmed that 2026 represents “the year of democracy,” within a vision aimed at reactivating elected institutions and renewing political legitimacies.⁽⁵⁾

The calls for Palestinian elections in late 2026 come within an exceptional political context, different from experiences of democratic transition or state-building elsewhere. Palestinians

(1) Pleas for the two-state solution at the New York conference, and Washington criticizes, (28 July 2025), Doha, Al Jazeera Net. [Link](#)

(2) Mahmoud Abbas sets 28 November as the date for Palestinian legislative elections, (9 July 2026), Paris, France 24. [Link](#)

(3) The Elections Commission publishes the amendment to the General Elections Law, (22 June 2026), Ramallah, Central Elections Commission. [Link](#)

(4) Interview: Mohammed al-Talbani, (5 July 2026), researcher in constitutional law, Gaza, Palestine.

(5) The President issues decisions specifying elections for the Palestinian National Council, (19 July 2025), Ramallah, Palestinian News & Info Agency (WAFA). [Link](#)

face a phase of reordering their political system amid the repercussions of a devastating war and the resulting mass displacement, economic and social collapse, and ambiguity surrounding the future of the land, the population, and national identity. In this context, elections appear as part of addressing a deeper crisis relating to the future of the Palestinian national project. The complications of this undertaking are compounded by the absence of comprehensive national consensus, and by the fact that calls for elections are tied to international and regional pressures pushing toward reshaping the political system within post-war arrangements. A paradox emerges here: the international community — which has not succeeded in ending the war or addressing the roots of the conflict — is showing growing interest in reforming the Palestinian Authority and renewing its legitimacy, at a time when the core issues related to the occupation and Palestinian statehood remain unresolved.⁽¹⁾

The most prominent challenges facing this track are the continuation of the Palestinian division, the absence of consensus on the nature of the transitional phase and on the Palestinian Authority's return to take charge of affairs in Gaza, in addition to the lack of clarity over the war's trajectory and whether it will lead to consensual national arrangements or to externally imposed solutions. There is also an absence of a shared national vision for the nature of the political system required after the war ends, which makes holding elections in this context exceedingly complex. It can therefore be argued that elections in this framework should be the culmination of a comprehensive, consensual political process, not its starting point.⁽²⁾

Should the electoral process not be linked to a comprehensive national mobilization aimed at confronting the major challenges, and not be built on a political consensus aimed at rebuilding the political system, it risks being understood as an attempt to lend legitimacy to the existing status quo and to the continued dominance of the current political leadership, thereby limiting the prospects for genuine change. In such a context, this could lead to higher rates of voter abstention.⁽³⁾

Logistical challenges also pose a major obstacle to holding elections, particularly in the Gaza Strip, where extensive infrastructure destruction has created significant difficulties in managing the electoral process. These include continued displacement, the inability to accurately update the voter registry, and difficulties in determining polling locations within shelters or destroyed areas — in addition to challenges related to guaranteeing the security of voters and electoral workers, ensuring freedom of movement, and the timely delivery of electoral materials. The continued restrictions on movement and communications further compound the difficulty of organizing a fair and comprehensive electoral process.⁽⁴⁾

This track faces major challenges, most notably Israel's rejection of the Palestinian Authority's return to Gaza, which reinforces the continued separation of Palestinian political geography, in addition to internal division that limits its capacity to act. Despite possessing political and national legitimacy and Arab and international support, it suffers from a gap between legitimacy and the capacity to translate that legitimacy into an effective presence on the ground, amid the progress of the other tracks in imposing new facts on the ground.

(1) Interview: Taysir Muheisen, (8 July 2026), researcher and writer on development, humanitarian affairs, and public policy, Gaza, Palestine.

(2) Interview: Azzam Shaath, (6 July 2026), researcher in political affairs, Gaza, Palestine.

(3) Interview: Imad Abu Rahma, (9 July 2026), researcher in political affairs, Gaza, Palestine.

(4) Interview: Taysir Muheisen, (8 July 2026), researcher and writer on development, humanitarian affairs, and public policy, Gaza, Palestine.

Nevertheless, this track remains the most consistent with Palestinian political and national considerations, being the closest to preserving the unity of Palestinian geography and political identity. Its success requires building a unified national position that transcends division and reactivates the institutions of the political system, in order to confront the risks of Gaza being reshaped outside its national context should the Israeli and American tracks continue to impose alternative arrangements.

Conclusion:

The conflict in Gaza is no longer only about the identity of the party that will govern the Strip in the “day after”; it is about Gaza’s future and its place within the Palestinian national project and the region. There is an Israeli track seeking to re-engineer the Strip’s security and geography and impose new facts on the ground; an American track working to craft international and administrative arrangements with security and economic dimensions; and a Palestinian track staking its future on elections and renewed legitimacy to restore the unity of the political system. Through this, Gaza appears to stand before an open conflict among competing projects over land, people, and the future.

Given Israel’s possession of field and security instruments of power, and its direct capacity to impose facts on the ground, the Israeli track appears the most capable of implementation at the current stage — especially in light of the challenges facing both the American and Palestinian tracks, whether in terms of political vision or the capacity to operate within the Strip. Yet imposing a security reality by force does not necessarily produce a sustainable political solution; it may instead exacerbate crises of legitimacy and stability, and reproduce conflict in new forms.

The central challenge facing Palestinians, therefore, is not only to confront the facts being imposed on the ground, but to build a unified national vision capable of overcoming division, unifying institutions, and translating political legitimacy into effective capacity to exert influence. Elections and the renewal of institutions should not be regarded merely as a procedural entitlement, but as a gateway to rebuilding the Palestinian political system and reclaiming the initiative. In the absence of comprehensive national consensus and a unified strategic vision, Gaza will remain exposed to a contest of others’ wills, while its future is drawn outside the framework of the Palestinian national project.